



improving has had a compounding effect on Gulveer's success. "If you are not already an accomplished athlete, it's hard to get entry into competitions. In Gulveer's case, when he first broke the national record in the 10,000m (at San Juan Capistrano), he wasn't even running in the main event because his timing wasn't considered good enough to be included in the starting list of that race. Now that he has improved so much, it will be a lot easier for him to get into other competitions. That's important because he has to keep competing in international events," says Simmons.

Continuous improvement

And there will have to be many more competitions. For all his progress as a runner, Gulveer missed out on the biggest competition of the year when he failed to qualify for the Paris Olympics in either the 5,000m or 10,000m.

"The automatic qualification

standard for that competition was just too fast for me (the qualification standard in the men's 5,000m was 13:05, while that in the 10,000m was 27:00). It was disappointing to miss out, but it reminded me of just how much I have to improve as a runner," he says.

Gulveer says he is up for that challenge. His primary focus for the 2025 season is to qualify for the World Championships. The qualifying standard for the 10,000m (27:00.00) is as strict as that for the Olympics, while that for the 5,000m (13:01.00) is even tougher. However, Gulveer believes he can get there. "In both my best 5,000m and 10,000m races, I felt that I had more to give. I think I can improve my time in the latter to a flat 27 minutes," he says.

These are not easy benchmarks to meet, though. Even Gulveer knows that much. Should he meet his goals for this season, he has even loftier targets for 2026 and beyond, leading up to the 2028 Olympics.

His coaches believe he can do

Uplifting right: Gulveer's new tractor was bought using part of the prize money he received for winning the Asian Games bronze. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

more than qualify. "He's still very young for a long-distance runner. His real peak will be at the end of this Olympic cycle," says Simmons. With the Olympic gold medal in the 10,000m at Paris being won in 26:43.14 and 5,000m in 13:13.66, Gulveer knows it's not impossible to dream of a medal either. But all that means more sacrifice.

It means more time away from his family and child. It will not be easy, but Gulveer has his sights set clearly. "When I left Pari at home, I knew I wouldn't be able to see her again for a long time. I don't think I will get a chance to go home until after the 2026 Asian Games. I wish I could be around her, but I have a very difficult target in front of me. Maybe when she is older, she will understand. I hope I will have something to show her for my absence," he says.